

British Museum - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

The British Museum: The First Museum of Everything

Founded in 1753 around the collections of the physician Hans Sloane, the British Museum was the first national public museum in the world — free, from the beginning, to “all studious and curious persons,” a genuinely radical Enlightenment idea when most collections were princely and private. It now holds around eight million objects, of which perhaps one percent is on display, and it sits at the center of the modern world’s sharpest cultural-property debates: the Parthenon sculptures, the Benin bronzes, the Rosetta Stone itself are all claimed by their countries of origin, and the museum’s traditional defense — the “universal museum” where world cultures can be compared side by side — is being renegotiated in real time. Whatever your view, the debate itself is worth having in front of the objects. The Great Court you enter through is worth a pause: Norman Foster’s 2000 roof, three thousand three hundred twelve glass panels, no two identical, turned what had been a hidden courtyard around the round Reading Room into the largest covered public square in Europe. The Reading Room at its center is where Marx wrote much of *Das Kapital*; Bram Stoker, Gandhi, and Virginia Woolf all held reader’s tickets. With a 3:30 slot and kids in tow, pick one civilization and go deep — the Egyptian sculpture gallery and the mummies upstairs are the classic ninety-minute raid.

Tell Me More: The Restitution Question, Properly

Since the debate will be in the air as you walk, here’s a fair sketch of it. The case for return: the Parthenon sculptures were removed between 1801 and 1812 under an Ottoman permission whose scope is disputed and whose original document doesn’t survive — Greece has never accepted its legitimacy; the Benin bronzes were taken in an explicitly punitive military expedition in 1897 and sold to fund it, about as clean a case of loot as exists; and origin countries argue that unified collections (all surviving Parthenon sculpture in Athens’s purpose-built Acropolis Museum, in sight of the building) serve scholarship and justice better than dispersal. The case for the status quo: the museum is barred by a 1963 Act of Parliament from permanently disposing of most objects, so trustees genuinely cannot simply hand things back; the universal-museum argument holds that seeing Egypt beside Assyria beside Greece beside Benin produces understanding no national museum can; and there are pragmatic anxieties about precedent across eight million objects. The ground is shifting though: institutions across Europe have begun returning Benin bronzes; long-term loan formulas are openly discussed for the Parthenon sculptures; and the museum’s own 2023 crisis — the discovery that a staff member had allegedly stolen and sold hundreds of small items over years — dented the “safest hands” argument at the worst possible moment. Wherever you land, have the argument in Room 18, in front of the marbles. They concentrate the mind.

The Parthenon Marbles, Up Close

Since the restitution argument is unavoidable here, spend a moment on what actually hangs in Room 18, because the sculptures reward close looking. Along one wall runs the Panathenaic frieze, a marble procession that once circled the top of the temple, hidden in shadow behind the columns, showing the citizens of Athens on the move, horsemen reining in mounts that rear and jostle, so alive you can almost

hear the hooves. Then the metopes, square panels of Lapiths wrestling Centaurs, civilization against chaos. And the pediment figures, carved fully in the round for a roof nobody could climb to, a reclining god, three seated goddesses in drapery so fine it looks wet, and the exhausted horse of the moon-goddess Selene, its head sinking, nostrils flared, at the very end of the night.

Two things most visitors never register. First, none of this was white. The Greeks painted their marble in strong colours, reds and blues, and added gilding and bronze fittings. The pure alabaster look we call classical is an accident of survival and, as we'll see, of scrubbing.

Which brings the darker footnote. In the late nineteen thirties, a wealthy donor named Joseph Duveen was funding a grand new gallery for the sculptures and wanted them gleaming white to match his idea of ancient purity. Workmen were set to clean several pieces with copper tools and a harsh abrasive, and they stripped away the honey-coloured surface the marble had earned over two thousand years, going into the stone itself. An internal inquiry admitted the damage could not be exaggerated, and the museum quietly buried the whole affair for decades. It surfaces now, awkwardly, whenever Athens presses its case. Lord Byron had got there first in spirit, savaging Lord Elgin in verse as a plunderer while the sculptures were still being prised off the temple. Stand here, look hard, and have the argument in front of the objects. They concentrate the mind better than any pamphlet.

Nineveh, and the Night the Flood Was Read

If the family's energy holds, detour into the Assyrian galleries, because they hold some of the greatest art the ancient world produced, and a story that belongs beside the Rosetta Stone. First, the sheer theatre of the place, the colossal human-headed winged bulls, the lamassu, that once guarded palace gates in what is now northern Iraq. Look at the legs, five of them, so the beast stands firm seen head-on and strides forward seen from the side, a deliberate trick of motion carved around seven hundred years before Christ. Then the North Palace reliefs of Ashurbanipal's lion hunt, made about six hundred and forty-five BC, arguably the finest depiction of animals in all antiquity, the dying lioness dragging her paralysed hindquarters the most quietly devastating image in the building. These came out of the ground in the eighteen forties, dug by Austen Henry Layard and his gifted assistant Hormuzd Rassam.

But the real treasure here is small and made of baked clay. Ashurbanipal was that rare thing, a king who could read, and he assembled the first great systematic library, thousands of cuneiform tablets gathered from across his empire, much of it now in this museum. And in eighteen seventy-two a self-taught curator named George Smith, a former banknote engraver who had taught himself to read cuneiform in his lunch hours, was working through a broken tablet when he realised he was reading an account of a great flood, a man told by a god to build a boat, to load it with his family and animals, and, after the waters rose, to send out a dove to search for land. A flood story centuries older than the one in Genesis. By the account of his colleagues, Smith leapt up, rushed around the room in a state of wild excitement, and began pulling off his clothes. What he had found was the eleventh tablet of the Epic of Gilgamesh, the oldest great poem humanity possesses. Two rooms apart, this museum holds the two objects that let us read the deep past, a stone from Egypt and a fistful of clay from Nineveh.

The Rosetta Stone and the Race to Read Egypt

The Rosetta Stone is a fragment of a granodiorite stela carrying a priestly decree of 196 BC affirming the cult of the teenage Ptolemy the Fifth — administratively dull content, world-historical form: the same text in hieroglyphic, demotic, and Greek. Found by French engineers at Rashid in 1799 during Napoleon’s Egyptian expedition, it was ceded to Britain under the 1801 Treaty of Alexandria — the painted captions on its sides, “Captured in Egypt by the British Army,” were left visible by curators as part of its history. The decipherment was a two-nation intellectual duel. Thomas Young, the English polymath, made crucial advances — establishing that cartouches held royal names and that some signs were phonetic. Jean-François Champollion, who had prepared his entire life for this and read Coptic, the descendant of ancient Egyptian, delivered the breakthrough in 1822: hieroglyphic writing was a mixed system, phonetic and symbolic at once. The famous story has him bursting into his brother’s office at the Institut de France crying “Je tiens l’affaire!” — I’ve got it — and collapsing. The consequence is easy to understate: three thousand years of Egyptian civilization went from mute to speaking. Every translated papyrus, every tomb inscription, every schoolboy’s copying exercise we can now read runs through this one stone.

Tell Me More: What the Egyptians Wrote

Decipherment’s real payoff is content, so here’s a sampler of what became readable. Administrative papyri revealed the world’s first documented labor strike: in the twenty-ninth year of Ramesses the Third, around 1157 BC, the elite tomb-builders of Deir el-Medina sat down beyond the temple walls because grain rations were weeks late — “we are hungry,” reads the scribe’s account — and the action worked, twice. The same village yielded thousands of ostraca, limestone flakes used as notepads: laundry lists, love poems (“my heart flutters hastily when I think of my love”), sick-day records — the absentee log survives, with excuses including “brewing beer” and “scorpion sting” — and a lively trade in fiction. Medical papyri showed sophisticated diagnosis mixed with spells; mathematical papyri showed scribes calculating pyramid slopes and dividing loaves among workers in unit fractions. The Book of the Dead, examples of which surround you upstairs, resolved into something precise: not a bible but a personalized kit of spells — customers paid by the chapter — for navigating an afterlife bureaucracy whose climax, the weighing of the heart against the feather of truth, includes history’s most comprehensive ethics checklist, the “negative confession”: I have not stolen, I have not made anyone weep, I have not polluted the water. Champollion himself got only a decade with his open door — he died at forty-one in 1832, having burned through his health — but he reached Egypt once, and reportedly read the monuments aloud, at sight, to his stunned companions.

The Stone’s Own Biography

The Rosetta Stone has a life story as eventful as anything written on it. Consider how it was found. It was not standing in a temple waiting to be admired. It had been broken up and reused, centuries ago, as ordinary building rubble, mortared into the wall of a fort at the mouth of the Nile that Napoleon’s engineers were refortifying. A French officer noticed the writing on a block in the wall. Salvation by accident.

Napoleon’s expedition was not only an army. He brought a hundred and sixty-seven scholars, the savants, whose vast survey of the country became the *Description de l’Égypte* and effectively launched the science of Egyptology. And they did something shrewd with the stone before it ever left their hands. They inked its surface and pressed paper onto it, taking impressions, and sent those copies to scholars across Europe. So when the British defeated the French and the stone changed owners, the intellectual race to read it was already loose in the world, running on paper the French had printed. You cannot capture a copy.

The handover itself was ill-tempered. As the French surrendered, their general Menou tried to keep the stone as personal property, insisting it was his private baggage rather than spoils of war, and had to be overruled. It reached London in eighteen oh two and was presented to the museum in the name of King George the Third, where it has sat almost ever since.

And here is the detail that surprises people who know the object only from photographs. For most of its time in London the stone looked black, and was often described as black basalt. It was nothing of the kind. Generations of curators had rubbed white chalk into the incised letters to make them readable and sealed the whole surface under a protective wax that darkened with handling. Only in nineteen ninety-nine was it finally cleaned, revealing grey granodiorite flecked with crystal and a soft pink vein running through one corner. Its true face had been hidden under a century of good intentions. And during the First World War, fearing bombardment, the museum sent it underground for safekeeping. Few objects this famous have spent so much of their fame in disguise, in transit, or in hiding.

Why the Stone Speaks Three Languages

Here is a question worth asking in front of the stone. Why three scripts at all? Why would a single decree be carved in hieroglyphic, in demotic, and in Greek? The answer is a small history lesson in who was actually running Egypt in one hundred and ninety-six BC. The answer is Greeks.

When Alexander the Great died, his general Ptolemy seized Egypt, and his descendants, the Ptolemies, ruled it for nearly three centuries as a foreign, Greek-speaking dynasty who mostly never bothered to learn the language of the people they governed. Cleopatra, the last of the line, three hundred years and many grandchildren later, was reportedly the first Ptolemy to trouble to speak Egyptian. So a royal decree in this kingdom needed three registers at once. Greek, for the ruling class who actually spoke it. Hieroglyphic, the ancient sacred script, for the gods and the temple priests. And demotic, the fast everyday cursive, for literate ordinary Egyptians. Three audiences, one message.

And the message itself is pure statecraft. Strip away the grandeur and the Rosetta Stone is a deal. The priests of Egypt formally grant divine honours to the boy-king Ptolemy the Fifth, and in exchange he confirms their tax breaks and temple privileges. Legitimacy traded for money, carved in granite and posted in the temples. Propaganda, essentially, which is why the same text was mass-produced across the country.

As for the two men who cracked it, the rivalry had an edge worth naming. Thomas Young was an English polymath of almost absurd range, the man who also demonstrated that light travels in waves and gave his name to a law of elasticity, and he treated hieroglyphs as a sideline, a puzzle for his spare hours. He got real distance, proving the cartouches held the phonetic spellings of royal names. But Jean-François Champollion had prepared his whole life for this single problem and, crucially, read Coptic, the last living descendant of the ancient Egyptian tongue, which let him hear the language behind the signs. The Englishman dabbled brilliantly, the Frenchman saw the whole system, and neither ever quite conceded to the other. The argument, faintly nationalist, has never entirely died. But the stone settled the real question. Egypt, after fourteen centuries of silence, could speak again.

Sutton Hoo and the Lewis Chessmen: Two Buried Worlds

The Sutton Hoo ship burial, excavated in the summer of 1939 as war loomed, rewrote the “Dark Ages.” Beneath a mound in Suffolk, Basil Brown — a self-taught local archaeologist hired by landowner Edith Pretty — uncovered the impression of a twenty-seven-meter ship, its timber long dissolved, and a burial chamber of staggering wealth: gold and garnet fittings of Anglo-Saxon workmanship at its finest, silver from Byzantium, coins from Francia, a lyre, and the iron-and-bronze helmet whose reconstructed face has become the icon of early England. The likely occupant is Raedwald of East Anglia, died around 625 — a king from the world of *Beowulf*, and the finds forced historians to abandon the idea of a crude, isolated post-Roman Britain: this was a court connected from Sweden to Constantinople. Pretty donated everything to the museum, still one of the largest gifts by a living donor. The Lewis Chessmen, twelfth-century, carved mostly from walrus ivory probably in Trondheim, Norway, were found in 1831 in a sand bank on the Isle of Lewis — ninety-odd pieces, likely a merchant’s stock, hidden and never retrieved. Their expressive faces — despairing queens, shield-biting berserker rooks — make them the most charismatic medieval objects in the museum. Note for Edinburgh next week: eleven of the chessmen live at the National Museum of Scotland, so the hoard itself is split between the two cities you’re visiting.

Tell Me More: Basil Brown, Edith Pretty, and the Berserkers

The human story of Sutton Hoo bears expanding. Edith Pretty was no ordinary landowner: widowed, spiritualist-inclined, she’d traveled to Egyptian excavations in her youth; local legend has a houseguest seeing spectral figures on the mounds, though her practical motive was straightforward curiosity. Basil Brown, hired through the Ipswich Museum for thirty shillings a week, was a tenant farmer’s son and self-taught polymath; his 1939 season notebooks record the moment ship rivets appeared in sequence and he realized he was inside a vessel the length of a tennis court. When the find’s importance emerged, Cambridge professionals took over and Brown was relegated — the treasure inquest, held in a village hall, awarded everything to Pretty as the mounds were on her land, and her donation to the museum was then the largest gift by a living person. She declined appointment as a Dame; Brown kept digging locally into his eighties, and the museum now names him in the gallery — restitution of credit, at least. The finds spent the war in the Aldwych tube tunnel. As for the Lewis hoard: the discovery tale has shifted between a cow uncovering a sand dune and a crofter’s spade, and an early keeper reportedly found the little figures so uncanny he suspected elves; the shield-biting rooks are “berserkers,” warriors of Odin whose battle-frenzy — biting shields, howling — appears in the sagas, and whose name survives in English every time someone goes berserk.

Reading the Treasure in the Case

Stand in front of the Sutton Hoo case and know what you’re looking at, because much of it is not quite what it seems. Take the famous helmet first. What you see is largely a reconstruction. When it came out of the ground it was hundreds of rusted, shattered fragments, and an early attempt in the nineteen forties got it wrong. In the early nineteen seventies a British Museum conservator named Nigel Williams took the whole thing apart and spent months, working from more than five hundred fragments, matching them by profile and curvature like the most forbidding jigsaw imaginable, to arrive at the face we now think of as early England. Only a fraction of the iron is original.

And that face is not English in style at all. Its closest relatives are Swedish, the helmets from Vendel and Valsgärde across the North Sea, which tells you this East Anglian king dressed in the fashion of Scandinavian royalty, part of a world that stretched from Suffolk to Uppland. Look at the face-mask

closely, and the eyebrows, nose and moustache resolve into a bird or dragon in flight, wings spread across the brows, its body running down the nose.

Then the goldwork, which is where the sophistication really shows. The great shoulder-clasps and the belt buckle are the finest Anglo-Saxon craftsmanship known. The buckle is hollow, worked all over with writhing interlaced beasts, and fitted with a hidden sliding catch, a puzzle-lock. The clasps are garnet cloisonné, hundreds of thin red stones cut to fit gold cells, each stone backed with a tiny sheet of gold foil scored to throw the light back at you, and the garnets themselves may have travelled from as far as India and Sri Lanka to reach a Suffolk grave. And do not skip the purse-lid. It once closed a pouch containing thirty-seven small gold coins, and here is the detective's gift, each coin came from a different mint across Frankish Gaul, and their dates let scholars pin the burial to around the six hundred and twenties. A dead king's spending money, still telling us the year he died.

The Vanished King and Two Altars

Here is a question that haunted Sutton Hoo for years. Was anyone actually in the ship? When the burial chamber was excavated, no body was found, and the acidic Suffolk sand is fierce enough to dissolve bone entirely. For a long time scholars genuinely debated whether this was a cenotaph, an empty memorial to a king buried elsewhere. The likeliest answer came from chemistry. Tests found raised levels of phosphate in the sand where a body would have lain, the ghost of a corpse that had simply melted into the ground, leaving its treasures arranged around an absence.

And whose absence? The strongest candidate is Raedwald, overlord of the English kingdoms, who died around the year six hundred and twenty-five, a king from the very world of Beowulf. What makes him the perfect occupant is a detail preserved by the monk Bede, writing a century later. Raedwald, Bede tells us, converted to Christianity but hedged his bets, keeping in one and the same temple an altar to Christ and, beside it, a second altar to the old gods, sacrificing to both. Now look again at this grave. It is a thoroughly pagan ship burial, a warrior sent to the afterlife with his weapons and his gold, in the old way. And yet among the treasures sat two silver spoons, inscribed in Greek lettering with the names Saul and Paul, the apostle before and after his conversion, quite possibly a christening gift. Paganism and Christianity, buried in the same boat. This is England caught precisely at its hinge, one foot in each world, and it is why Sutton Hoo matters far beyond its gold.

One more thing, for the record. The great ship in Mound One is famous, but the cemetery holds around eighteen mounds, and almost all were robbed centuries ago. The exception is Mound Seventeen, opened intact in nineteen ninety-one, which held a young warrior of about twenty-five buried side by side with his horse, complete with a beautiful harness. The grave-robbers had dug their pit straight down the middle of the mound, passed neatly between the two graves, found nothing, and given up. Sometimes history survives on sheer bad luck, someone else's.

The Chessmen and the Piece in the Drawer

The Lewis Chessmen deserve a closer read than their charm alone. Seventy-eight pieces turned up in eighteen thirty-one in a sandbank on the Isle of Lewis, almost certainly a merchant's stock, hidden and never reclaimed, carved sometime between about eleven fifty and twelve hundred, mostly from walrus ivory, probably in Trondheim in Norway, where a matching queen was later found. But look past the wonderful glum faces and they tell you how a whole game was changing.

Chess had travelled west from India and Persia, and in its original form the piece standing beside the king was a war-elephant. By the time these were carved, medieval Europe had quietly reinvented that piece as a bishop, a churchman in mitre and robes, and the Lewis bishops are among the earliest depictions of the bishop in chess anywhere in the world, a small marble record of the game becoming European and

Christian. The rooks are foot-soldiers, and a handful of them are the berserkers, biting the rims of their shields in battle-fury. There are kings on their thrones, queens resting a cheek on one hand in an attitude somewhere between grief and boredom, and rows of plain pawns that never got faces at all.

Why a Scottish beach? Because Lewis in the twelfth century was not Scottish, it was Norwegian, a stop on the busy sea-road linking Scandinavia to Norse Dublin. These pieces were passing through a Viking-age trade network, not lost at the edge of the world but dropped in the middle of a highway. Today the hoard is split, most of it in London, eleven pieces at the National Museum of Scotland in Edinburgh, so if Edinburgh is on your itinerary you can visit both halves, and Scotland would dearly like them reunited.

And a coda that sounds invented but is not. In twenty nineteen a family in Edinburgh had an old walrus-ivory figure in a drawer, bought by their grandfather in nineteen sixty-four for five pounds and long thought to be some anonymous antique carving. Someone finally recognised the glowering face. It was one of the missing Lewis warders, absent since eighteen thirty-one. It sold at auction for seven hundred and thirty-five thousand pounds. Somewhere out there, four more pieces are still missing. Check your drawers.